hit me in the stomach. I thought I was going to be sick. I even hoped for a split second that I'd just not heard Glenn saying 'Beckham'. I looked across at Gary Neville. He was looking back at me. Was he surprised, too? Or just watching to see how I might react? Of course it was a blow to my pride and that would always be something you have to be mature enough to overcome. What really knocked me sideways, though, was not having any real understanding of why the manager had made his decision.

I've always tried to have a professional attitude to training. I love it almost as much as I love playing. That morning, though, was a complete waste of time. I felt so low. I was so angry I couldn't force myself to work properly. Glenn must have been able to see that I wasn't coping with what I'd been told. I suppose I should have known what would happen next: as soon as we finished the session, he announced who would be taking questions from the press that afternoon. That list, of course, included my name. It was horrible. I've never been that good at hiding my emotions. If I'm unhappy or down, people just know. I did that press conference and didn't say anything out of turn, but it must have been pretty obvious something wasn't right. A couple of the other players got calls straight afterwards from journalists who were helping them do World Cup diaries for the papers. 'What's wrong with David?' they were asking. 'Has he been left out of the team?'

Lots of managers play mind games with the press and with opposing teams. Here, it seemed to me the England manager was playing mind games with one of his own players. That's what upset me the most. I didn't realize it there and then, but I wasn't going to enjoy France 98 from that press conference onwards. I didn't know which way to turn. I couldn't even decide who to speak to for support or advice. I called Victoria first. She was shocked and I think, instinctively, she would have told me to leave and come to America straight away, where the Spice Girls were on tour. She didn't say that, which is probably just as well; I felt so low I might almost have been tempted. Then I talked to Dad. He couldn't believe it, either, and at least reassured me that I wasn't over-reacting. He told me it was understandable that I was so upset.

I realized I had to speak to Glenn. I can still remember standing in the hotel reception, oblivious to everything and everybody around me. Then I saw the manager coming through, on his way out to play golf.

'I have to talk to you about this. Why have you dropped me? I need to know the reason.'